# 2 Signal types

**This chapter covers**

- What different signal types are
- When and how to use a certain signal type
- The costs and benefits of each signal type
- How to figure out which signals are relevant
- Determining signal baselines

In the context of observability, signals play a central role: this is the intel we're basing our decisions on. On a high level, we can differentiate between signals numerical in nature (e.g., the number of service invocations) and signals that carry textual payload that requires human interpretation (e.g., a log line).

As discussed in chapter 1, the system under observation, or just *system* (e.g., a Kubernetes application or a serverless app based on Lambda functions), emits signals from various sources. You, as a human, or equally a piece of software, then use these signals to understand the system and make decisions to influence it. There is a one-to-many relation between the system and sources. Your system typically involves compute, storage, and network, each of these representing a signal source. We will cover the sources in detail in chapter 3.